

FROM SKILLS TO SALARIES

Rethinking India's Employability Challenge

A certificate celebrates learning. A salary celebrates opportunity.

The loudest applause at a convocation is usually reserved for degrees. At Sun Foundation's Multi Skill Development Centre in Ludhiana, it came for something else. As graduating trainees walked across the stage, they proudly received their NSDC mark sheets. Moments later, they were handed appointment letters from leading employers. By the end of the ceremony, 1,044 young men and women had secured employment opportunities—transforming what is often the end of an academic journey into the beginning of a professional one.

This moment reflects the larger mission of Sun Foundation, which operates seven Skill Development Centres across Delhi and Punjab, skilling and placing over 5,000 youth annually.



The Ludhiana convocation demonstrated a simple principle: skill development must lead directly to livelihoods.

That moment reflects one of India's most pressing development challenges.

Every year, millions of young Indians complete their education, yet employers continue to face a shortage of job-ready talent. The challenge is no longer access to education—it is employability.

India's demographic dividend will be realised only when education translates into meaningful employment

FROM CERTIFICATES TO CAREERS

This belief has guided the work of Dr. Vikramjit Singh Sahney, Padma Shri Member of Parliament, Chairman of Sun Foundation, Vice Chairman of the Central Apprenticeship Council and former Board Member of the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC), for over two decades.

Dr. Sahney has long maintained that vocational education should never be viewed as a second choice to higher education. Instead, it is one of the most effective pathways to economic mobility and workforce readiness. His philosophy is simple yet powerful: a certificate has value only when it leads to livelihood.

That philosophy has shaped Sun Foundation's Skills-to-Salaries approach—an employability-first model where success is measured not by enrolments or certifications, but by careers created.

WHY TRADITIONAL SKILLING NEEDS A NEW APPROACH

India has made significant investments in expanding vocational education. Between April 2024 and March 2026, over 27 lakh youth were trained reflecting the country's commitment to building a future-ready workforce. Yet, the employability challenge remains. Despite having one of the world's youngest populations, only around 4.1% of Indians aged 15–59 are formally skilled.

Closing the gap between classrooms and careers demands an employability-first approach where industry drives learning and meaningful employment becomes the ultimate measure of success.

Sun Foundation's Skills-to-Salaries Framework rests on five interconnected principles:

- **Access Without Financial Barriers** - Every deserving youth should have access to free, high-quality skill development, certification and placement support.
- **Industry Shapes the Classroom** - Training is designed around employer requirements rather than academic assumptions. Through Institute Management Committees (IMCs) and continuous industry engagement, employers help shape curricula, strengthen practical learning and ensure that programmes remain aligned with evolving workplace needs.
- **Learning by Doing** - Modern labs, digital classrooms and Industry 4.0-enabled infrastructure expose trainees to real work environments long before they enter the workforce.
- **Placement Begins on Day One** - Employers remain partners throughout the learning